

CLAREFLYNNEDIT

Travel Radio Australia, we're on the Gold Coast this month in a beautiful apartment here, right in the middle of Surfers Paradise. And we're with the fabulous Claire Flynn. Claire, welcome to the program.

Thank you, it's great to be here. Well, I'm always here. Just about, besides my travels.

That's right, and you travel all around the world. And you've been a relationship coach, a sex therapist, you do all sorts of different things. And not just that, but other things.

Tell us a bit about what you do. Well, you know, started off actually in dating agencies going back in the 80s. Then I went into real estate and came full circle around and became not like a dating coach again, but went into around dating to relationships and sexuality and ended up co-authoring a book called *You Can Live the Life of Your Dreams*.

And in that book, I did chapter eight, which was all on female sexuality and intimacy. So, yeah, that was my passion for many years. That's very important to a lot of people these days.

And as we know, all the old norms are out the window these days, isn't it? Because the way people date is different and they have the online dating and all that kind of thing. It's all changed. It has definitely.

And I look at the way we did dating going back. Actually, Aldwyn has a friend also in dating that was working for the same company I was back in the 80s. And she's still doing it the old fashioned way, which works so much better, I believe, than the digital dating swipe, swipe, swipe, swipe.

Because now it's too difficult. More people are getting addicted to the dating rather than actually being serious about, oh, I want to actually have someone long term. It's too easy just to swipe again and get to the next one.

That's the difference, I think, from today's type dating to how we used to do it back when I was in dating agencies. We were going to weddings and we're going to engagement parties and people were having long term relationships. Now it's like, who are you with this week? It's changed.

It has certainly changed. And the thing is that there's not the venues. And I feel sorry for young people these days because it is so expensive to go out to clubs and bars and places like that where it never used to be that expensive.

And the music has changed a lot too. And you don't have that cohesive music following that everyone is into. Everyone's in different styles of music and things.

So tell us about what you're up to these days. What's happening? Well, you know, these days,

after doing a bit of travel myself, I traveled to New Orleans. That's where I met Kingston back in 2019 briefly.

We actually continue to speak quite a lot on Instagram and WhatsApp over the whole COVID period because we couldn't go to each other's country. That sort of evolved. And now Kingston's here and got his temporary permanent residence, which is fantastic.

We've decided to sort of look at business together and how we can bring modelling dating agencies together. That's not happening. Instead, we're bringing a bit of New Orleans together and we're bringing in the snowballs and snow machines, which are very different.

So we're going down a very different path. But it's something that we can, you know, we're both passionate about. And it's, yeah, yeah.

So it's something different. And what about your background early on in life? Did you grow up here on the Gold Coast or another part of Australia? I grew up on the Gold Coast. I went to school on the Gold Coast.

I ended up being quite adventurous, quite young. I won't go into all of that. That's a few books, a few chapters.

But I ended up going over the Nullarbor in a little Suzuki mighty boy at 17 years of age with one other girl who was 18, which was just a crazy survival trip. Got to WA. Cut a long story short, ended up in WA for nearly 20 years.

A lot of things happened there. And that's where going back 17 years ago, I had a near-fatal motorbike accident. In WA.

And I suppose it was something to do with the accident I had that ended up bringing me back to the Gold Coast. There was a few traumas, not just with myself, my mum and I losing my brother at 41. I think that was a couple of years after my accident.

I thought it was time to come back to the Gold Coast and, you know, be close to where my mum is as well. And that trip that you did would have been incredible. So it was just you and another girl, 17, 19 years old, travelling across Australia in a beaten up old car.

And wow, any highlights from that that you can tell us? OK, I'll give you one highlight. It was so hot, we drove half of it naked. Well, that would have been interesting for the truck drivers and everybody going across there.

No, the truck drivers, those road trains blew us off the road. So that's the only sort of blonde we had along that road. And we had a little Maltese dog with us as well.

And fluffy car seat covers. I remember them because I'm thinking, this is not good. We're on

Lamb's Wall naked.

It's just sort of like a bit uncomfortable after a while. But the other thing we had on that trip, because that's going back in the 80s. We only had tapes then.

We forgot to bring music except for one tape. And that was Lulu. Remember Lulu back in the 80s? Yeah.

We listened to Lulu for the whole trip. And that's right across Australia. That's like days and days and days and days.

It felt like weeks. It felt like weeks. When you drive the Nullarball, it's like you feel like it looks the same the whole way.

But you feel like you're driving uphill. And as you're driving uphill, you never get to the top of the hill. We keep going, we want to get to the top of the hill.

But that hill is not coming to us. We're just driving. I could write another few chapters or a book on just the trip over the Nullarball.

Just briefly, I'll tell you another highlight of the Nullarball because we were running out of fuel. Now we're in a Suzuki Mighty Boy, which is like driving a lawnmower. They've only got a small engine, very small engine.

Driving that and it's running out of fuel. And we're like, okay. I don't know how we were smart enough at 17, 18 years of age, but we were.

Let's drive slow at 20, 30 k's an hour to save the fuel. Roll down the hills. Let's not put our foot on the accelerator too much.

And we like took that car, something like 80 k's on empty. And we found a little town. The first thing we found was a hotel.

We stopped at the hotel. We stopped at the hotel and we put our head in the hotel and there's about 16 men in there. I don't think they've seen a woman in years.

I hope you've got your clothes on. Oh no, we definitely, definitely had our clothes on. Definitely had our clothes on then.

And anyway, they've all just like looked at us. They didn't say a word. They looked shocked.

And we just, I just looked and said, do you know where a service station is? And then they went, oh, they started laughing. Oh, we've got one, but it's not open. But if you need somewhere to stay, we've got a room.

We went, no, we're fine. Thank you. So we drove to the service station.

We were so scared. We put a sheet up around the window so no one could see in. And we slipped in the service station to the next morning so we could get the fuel.

We were so scared because we were like, this car is so light. Those 16 guys could have easily come and picked that car up and taken that car with us in it wherever they wanted to. They didn't, thank goodness.

But we were fine. We woke up the next morning, got some fuel and headed back towards Perth. What an amazing story.

That's incredible. This could be a movie, really. Oh my God.

How many series do you want? We could do a series. Forget the movie. We've got, we've got, we've got a series to do here.

But yeah, it was, it was a crazy trip over the Nollabore. So once I got to Perth, the funny thing was, it was another story. I got to the stories.

But once we got to Perth, I didn't have any money. We ran out of money by that time. And the girl I was with, she actually owned the car.

So she in a way dumped me, left me, left me stranded in Perth. And I'm like, I've got nowhere to live. I don't know anyone.

I'm 17 years old. I've got no money. What do I do? So what I did is I went to the local hotel in Northbridge called the Aberdeen.

And there was a group of, they looked at Italian, Spanish guys all standing there. And I just walked straight up to them all, put myself in the middle of all these men. And I looked at them and I said, does anyone here got a job in a room? And they were all looking at me.

I said, yeah, I need money and I need somewhere to live. So one guy, one Spanish guy, Clint, he says, I've got a room. And I went, okay, great.

And this other guy, Macedonian, he says, I've got a job for you. What can you do? I say, I can sell anything. And he said, okay, I've got a sales job in a directory.

So it was facsimile directory. How crazy is that? So I went straight into work and I still know those guys today. That is incredible, isn't it? It's the ultimate road trip on the smell of an oily rag, basically.

You got back here to the Gold Coast and you went over to New Orleans to meet the love of your life. And he's moved over here now. Well, that happened like 30 years later.

There's a lot that happened in between me and Kingston, believe that. Yeah, so let's fast forward from 17 to, we're looking at about 25, 27 years later. I went to New Orleans and New Orleans was like, I was saying to Kingston the other day, actually, isn't it funny how we're both got, you know, how we've connected when New Orleans wasn't even really on my bucket list of a place to visit.

I ended up in New Orleans by accident and it was one of the girls that stayed with me at my house, Airbnb, actually, in Bundal in 2017, roughly. 2017, yes, she moved to New Orleans. She was quite an introvert.

And she called me and said, Claire, I've been in New Orleans for two years now and I still haven't met anyone. I just go to work into my apartment. I'm too scared to go anywhere because there's a lot of crime here.

There's this and that and everything. And she says, can you come over? And I said, yeah, of course, I'll be over. So I bought my ticket and I went to New Orleans.

I get to her apartment. I see there's a red dress run on and I said, come with me on this red dress run. And she says, oh, no, no, no, I'm not going to do that.

And I said, all right, well, I'm going to do it. And she said, OK, so I went and got all my gear for the red dress run. And and I went on this red dress run.

I had so, so much fun that I didn't come back for three days. I ended up meeting these couple of guys and up at the Hilton. OK, they looked after me.

I went to this birthday party and we just partied in the streets in New Orleans for the next few days. I'm thinking, and she's scared to come out in this place. I can't stop.

I just loved it. So I felt the feel of New Orleans very, very quick. And I felt at home straight away.

And yeah, it's a place I know will always be drawn by now. You know, my my partner's from New Orleans. So we're always going to be going back to New Orleans and have a big drawcard for New Orleans.

So the least expected place that I thought in the world is. Yeah, I think once you've been in New Orleans and it takes a bit of your heart, it's it's always going to be with you. Oh, yes, definitely.

New Orleans is one of the most wonderful places in the world and the friendliest too. That's very friendly. The Southerners are like that.

They open their doors, their their heart, their food, their food. They open all that to you. And I've experienced that in many different areas in New Orleans, like not just in New Orleans, but out in the country in New Orleans, a little bit.

And going back last time with Kingston to his best friend's wedding and up in Donaldsonville and meeting Kingston's family and, you know, just all beautiful people. And it's yeah, it's really great to be a part of that. Well, Claire, thank you so much for being part of the program's fascinating stories about your trips to Australia and New Orleans.

And how can people find you online in your social media? On my Instagram, I'm Claire Flynn. I think it's Claire Flynn Author. You can find me there.

And just on Facebook, it's just under Claire Flynn Gold Coast. There's a couple of Claire Flinns. I know that because I met one that was in the same program I was in years ago.

So don't get confused. Just look for the fabulous blonde on there, Claire Flynn Author. And thank you, Kingston, for being with us as well.

You're welcome, man. Thank you. Thanks for being on the program.

Yeah, thank you.